MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR/IMPROVEMENT/REAPPEARANCE

EXAMINATION APRIL 2026

SECOND SEMESTER

Multi-Disciplinary Courses (MDC) - MG2MDCHIS100 - FILMIC

APPROACHES TO HISTORY

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Answer Scheme

Part A: Short Answers

Answer any 5 questions. Each carries 2 marks.

1. **How does films influence society and vice versa?**
   Films act as a mirror to society, reflecting current cultural values, anxieties, and political ideologies. Conversely, cinema influences social behavior, public opinion, and fashion trends.
2. **Explain how *Elipathayam* uses cinematic language to depict social stagnation.**
   Adoor Gopalakrishnan uses slow pacing, claustrophobic framing, and the metaphor of the "rat trap" to symbolize the decay of the feudal system and the protagonist's inability to change.
3. **Mention the cardinal ideas discussed in MSS Pandian's *Image Trap*.**
   The book explores how "screen images" are constructed to create a messianic political identity, specifically analyzing the cult of personality surrounding M.G. Ramachandran in Tamil Nadu.
4. **Explain the importance of cinema in representing the past.**
   Cinema provides a sensory and emotional gateway to history, visualizing material culture (costumes, architecture) and making historical narratives accessible to the masses.
5. **Clarify how *Bhramayugam* represents power dynamics.**
   The film uses a monochromatic palette and a master-slave dialectic within a traditional *Mana* (ancestral home) to explore the corruptive and cyclical nature of absolute power.
6. **Compare Pierre Sorline's and Natalie Zemon Davies's historiographical methods.**
   Sorline focuses on film as a document of the time it was produced, while Davies treats film as a legitimate historical tool that can supplement textual evidence if handled with professional rigor.
7. **Discuss an important manner in which filmic representation differs from textual.**
   Filmic representation is audio-visual and multi-sensory, allowing for "simultaneity" (multiple events in one frame), whereas textual representation is typically linear and analytical.
8. **How does *Oru Vadakkan Veeragadha* reinterpret traditional narratives?**
   It subverts the traditional *Vadakkan Pattukal* by reimagining the legendary villain Chandu as a tragic, misunderstood hero, thus challenging the "official" ballad history.

Part B: Short Essay

Answer any 4 questions. Each carries 5 marks.

9. How do films balance imagination with realism?
Discussion on "creative license" versus mise-en-scène; filling archival gaps with narrative drama while maintaining visual authenticity.

10.What is the role of films in educating audiences about historical events?
Cinema as "public history"; its impact on collective memory and its ability to simplify complex events for a general audience.

11. Critique the blurring of fact and fiction by the film makers.
Analysis of the ethical responsibility of filmmakers; how dramatic tension can sometimes overshadow historical accuracy.

12.How do films reflect the aspirations and struggles of a nation?
Cinema as a tool for nation-building; reflecting social reforms, independence movements, or cultural identity crises.

13. Critique the historical framing of 1956, Central Travancore as a cinematic exploration of migration and land dispossession in Kerala's high ranges.
Focus on the settler narrative; Christian migration to Idukki/Wayanad and the resulting social and environmental changes as depicted in cinema.

14. How has the study of film history evolved during time?
Shift from technical/biographical histories to cultural and sociological approaches; the inclusion of spectatorship studies.

15.Discuss the differences between Biopics and Costume dramas.
Biopics focus on the life of a specific person (accuracy-driven); Costume dramas focus on the "spirit" of an era, often with

fictional plots.

Part C: Essay Questions

Answer any 2 questions. Each carries 10 marks.

16. Briefly describe the concept of Reenactment.

Definition of reenactment; its use in documentaries to "witness" the past; psychological and historical implications of re-performing events.

17. Evaluate the role of cinema as a representation of past.

The "Visual Turn" in history; cinema's ability to create a "historical world"; comparison between archival evidence and cinematic interpretation.

18.Analyse how *Chemmeen* constructs its historical setting through visuals and sound.

Use of the sea as a character; Salil Chowdhury's music; Marcus Bartley's cinematography; the construction of the Kadappuram (coastal) mythos.

19.Evaluate whether films can represent history with the same rigour as written sources.

Comparative analysis of methodology; the limitations of the camera versus the pen; the concept of "cinematic truth" versus "factual truth".